duty to counsel patients against taking decisions that are medically unsafe."

Taking these drugs, in fact, can cause what have come to be called the 'Ozempic face', 'Ozempic butt' and 'Ozempic hair'. The first refers to a pinched face on account of sudden weight loss, the second to a sagging posterior for the same reason and the third to hair loss due to bodily changes. Muscle loss is another adjunct of sudden weight loss. As Dr Mohit Sharma, senior consultant for internal medicine at Amrita Hospital, Faridabad, explains, "The body usually uses glucose in the blood first. If it doesn't find enough there, it taps glycogen stores. If that doesn't work, it uses protein for energy. Your muscles are made of protein, and that's how muscle mass reduces."

Nutritionists like Dr Ishi Khosla also worry about the effects of such medicines on gut health. "The modern gut has already taken such a beating," she says. "Taking medicines that alter how your digestion works could do more harm than good. A disturbed gut flora is linked to nearly 300 different medical conditions, including mood disorders."

THE REBELLION OF RYBELSUS

In India, Rybelsus is prescribed for treatment of Type 2 diabetes. But ask around—patients, doctors and wellness clinics—and you find the off-label use of Rybelsus even for non-diabetics. While it is not illegal for a doctor to prescribe the drug as they see fit for a non-diabetic, as Jayaseelan clarifies, "A manufacturer or a doctor cannot promote them for use in something that has not been granted approval."

Thus at the Kokilaben Ambani Hospital in Mumbai, Dr Manoj Jain, a surgeon trained in bariatric and metabolic procedures, says that the demand for Rybelsus among non-diabetics is up and he himself has recommended it for such patients. "I have observed 10 to 25 per cent loss of weight in those with BMI between 22.5 and 32.5," he says.

₹4.74
LAKH CRORE
INDIA'S WEIGHT LOSS MARKET as of Jan. 2024, according to commerce to insights technology company Pharmarack

$603
BILLION
CURRENT M-CAP OF DANISH FIRM NOVO NORDISK. Its rival US pharma giant Eli Lilly is ahead of it with $754 bn, both racing to become the world's first trillion-dollar pharma companies

M-cap figures as on March 13

Dr Chaturvedi, too, notes the off-label use of Rybelsus. "Doctors do use oral semaglutide for people who do not have diabetes since we don't have Wegovy here and we also do not have any effective medication for obesity, which is a growing major health concern."

However, semaglutide's runaway popularity as an elixir for weight loss, fuelled by celeb testimonies and extensive marketing, has triggered a gold rush for the drug. "Twenty years ago," says Jayaseelan, "the world was running after Prozac. Today, it is semaglutide. There are certainly many merits of the drug, but the marketing has been so strong that it is being seen as a magic pill to all our modern health concerns." The downside of this soaring demand has been a shortage of the medicines. Novo Nordisk has said supply will be limited till the end of 2024. Verma, who had been going to Dubai for the medicine, is now struggling to find it. "Some clinics have a long waitlist, no matter how much you are willing to pay," she says. Others are sourcing the drugs from chemists who are getting the variants manufactured in Egypt and Dubai. The fake Ozempic racket, too, is booming—it has already been found in at least 14 countries, including the UK, Germany, Egypt and Russia. The FDA is working with Europol, Interpol and 23 other law enforcement agencies towards quality control of weight loss drugs.

More than anything, the shortage of drugs has affected those who have already been taking this drug and suddenly do not find them available. "I am about to get married in four months," says Snigdha Sharma, 29, a Bengaluru-based IT professional, who has a BMI of 24. "I was taking Wegovy at a Los Angeles clinic to knock off some weight. But, now, doctors say I will have to wait a few months because I am not really obese, just slightly overweight. However, having taken it for three months, I fear the 3-4 kilos I lost will return."

That is arguably the biggest disadvantage of being on these drugs. Discontinue them, and the weight returns with a vengeance in the absence of suitable lifestyle or dietary changes. Losing weight and putting it back on cyclically, in turn, can cause inflammation-driven cellular injury. "Every cell needs glucose for survival," says Dr Wasir. "If you give it sometimes more and sometimes less, it is a metabolic insult to the cell and can cause inflammation."

DIABETIC'S DILEMMA

If you are severely diabetic or morbidly obese, Ozempic could well be the answer you are looking for. But in a country where the National Health Accounts Estimates pegged out-of-pocket health expenses at 52 per cent of total health expenditure in 2019-2020, the